

Deniz Sanin

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Academic Positions

Assistant Professor, Department of Economics, University of South Carolina, 08/2022 -

Visiting Scholar, Department of Economics, Harvard University, 01/2024-09/2024, 01/2026-08/2026

Visiting Scholar, Department of Economics & Economic Growth Center, Yale University, 01/2023-08/2023

Education

Ph.D. in Economics (with Distinction), Georgetown University, 2016-2022

Visiting Research Fellow, Women and Public Policy Program, Harvard University, 2021-2022

Dissertation: "Essays in Development, Labor and Gender Economics", Advisor: Garance Genicot

M.A. in Economics, Duke University, 2013-2015

B.A. in Economics, Minor in Mathematics (with High Honors), Sabancı University, 2009-2013

Research Fields

Development Economics, Labor Economics, Political Economy, all with a focus on gender

Working Papers

"Women's Employment, Husbands' Economic Self-Interest and Domestic Violence" Revise and Resubmit (2nd Round), American Economic Review

This paper presents evidence that providing employment opportunities to women decreases domestic violence when the husband has economic self-interest in the wife's work capacity. I use the government-induced rapid expansion of the coffee mills in Rwanda in the 2000s, which increased the value of coffee farmer couples' output and provided wage employment for women. Since the mill operates only during the harvest months, the husband's cost of physically incapacitating his wife changes within the year. This variation, in conjunction with novel monthly administrative records on domestic violence hospitalizations, provides a way to distinguish the incapacitation cost mechanism from the rise in women's bargaining power and household income, which are identified by multiple rounds of household survey data.

"When Do Domestic Violence Laws Work? Female-Biased Sex Ratios, Marriage Markets and Social Environments"

This paper studies when domestic violence laws effectively reduce domestic violence, focusing on Rwanda's 2008 Gender-Based Violence Law, which criminalized domestic violence and allowed unilateral divorce upon abuse. I first show that the law increased divorce and reduced domestic violence in villages that had been exposed to the hate-radio broadcasts during the 1994 genocide, where exposure—due to Rwanda's mountainous topography—led to higher levels of genocidal violence. I then demonstrate, both theoretically and empirically, that two mechanisms drive these effects: the marriage market matching channel and the social environment channel. In radio-exposed villages, genocidal violence created female-biased sex ratios through male death and incarceration, producing male scarcity for cohorts marrying shortly after the genocide. These

cohorts experienced more violent marriages before the law but a sharp rise in divorce and a substantial decline in domestic violence after the law, reflecting the law's impact through the marriage market channel. Younger cohorts, who did not face marriage market imbalances but lived in environments shaped by female-biased sex ratios, also experienced lower domestic violence and weaker acceptance of wife-beating, suggesting a deterrence effect operating through the social environment channel. The decline in justification is particularly pronounced among women who, prior to the law, lived within the 4-km catchment area of a coffee mill, where both cohorts interacted in the workplace. These patterns suggest that the law altered prevailing social norms by increasing the credibility of exit through divorce and reducing the social acceptability of violence, even among women not directly affected by the initial marriage market shock. Using the universe of hospital records on gender-based violence and post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), I rule out genocide exposure and PTSD as alternative mechanisms. Overall, the results show that the effectiveness of domestic violence laws depends on both the marriage market in which women marry—which shapes the type of partner they match with—and the social environment they subsequently face—which determines the credibility of women's outside option.

"The Power of Policy Incentives: Female Labor Supply, Fertility and Parental Leave Policy Design" with Mary Ann Bronson

Parental leave (PL) policies vary widely across countries, creating different incentives for childbearing and maternal labor supply. Yet, most empirical studies find that PL policy has negligible effects on these variables. This paper provides new evidence about the effects of PL policy design on women's outcomes. We first show that the standard quasi-experiment in the literature, which relies on regression discontinuities around PL reform dates, understates the true impact of PL policies for a simple reason: treatment and control groups share the same policy exposure for most of the evaluation period, making it difficult to isolate meaningful differences in outcomes. Using event studies from the U.K., Sweden, Austria, and Germany, we then show that women's labor force participation, PL take-up, and fertility choices closely track the incentives embedded in each country's policy design. Next, we build a dynamic model of women's work and fertility decisions, allowing us to simulate the effects of policies with varying durations, compensation structures, and eligibility criteria. The model replicates the small quasi-experimental estimates in the literature but shows that the true policy effects are far larger, in some cases increasing women's employment by 10 percentage points over the ten years after first birth, while also boosting fertility. Calibrating the model to U.K. data, we show that when exposing U.K. women to Swedish, Austrian, or German policies, they make work and childbearing choices that mirror those in those countries, confirming the power of policy incentives. Finally, we examine policy designs that maximize both labor force participation and fertility. We find that policies with moderate leave duration and generous wage replacement simultaneously boost employment and birth rates. Our findings indicate that the design of parental leave matters far more than past estimates imply, with lasting effects on women's careers and family choices.

Work in Progress

"Productive Women, Valuable Wives: Bride Price, Domestic Violence and Economic Development"

"Veiling Laws, Identity and Female Labor Supply: Evidence from Administrative Data and a Field Experiment" with Suzanna Khalifa

"Jobs and Domestic Violence Against Women and Men: Evidence from East Africa and the United States"

Invited Presentations († co-author)

2025: ASSA Annual Meeting, Yale University (Economic Growth Center ECD-WEE Conference), World Bank (Workshop on Policy Options for Reducing Violence Against Women at Scale), Society of Labor Economists Annual Meeting (needed to decline), Stanford SITE Gender, GCER Alumni Conference (Georgetown)

2024: ASSA Annual Meeting[†], NBER Summer Institute: The Micro and Macro Perspectives of the Aggregate Labor Market/Micro Data and Macro Models[†], Sabanci University, State University of New York (SUNY) Binghamton, IMF (Gender Seminar Series), NEUDC (Northeastern)

2023: NBER Development/BREAD Program Fall Meeting, The Economics of Violence and Harassment Against Women Conference (Stanford), Yale University (Joint Development & Labor-Public Lunch), North American Summer Meeting of the Econometric Society (UCLA), Society of Labor Economists Annual Meeting[†], The Annual Conference of the American Society of Health Economists

2022: NBER Summer Institute: Gender in the Economy, North American Summer Meeting of the Econometric Society (Miami Herbert Business School), Society of Labor Economists Annual Meeting, University of South Carolina (job-talk), Yale University, 100 Years of Economic Development Conference (Cornell), FROGEE Conference (Stockholm Institute of Transition Economics), LSE Management (job-talk, post-doc), NEUDC (Yale)

2021: Harvard Kennedy School WAPPP, Society of Labor Economists Annual Meeting, European Winter Meetings of The Econometric Society & EJM (BSE), Midwest International Economic Development Conference (Northwestern), North American Summer Meeting of the Econometric Society (Université du Québec à Montréal), Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting, Annual Washington Area Development Economics Symposium, Society of Household Economics Annual Meeting (Boston University), Midwest Economic Association Meetings, Delhi Winter School (DSE & The Econometric Society)

2020: European Winter Meetings of The Econometric Society & EJM (Nottingham), Econometric Society World Congress (Bocconi), Midwest Economic Association Meetings (canceled), Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting, Delhi Winter School (DSE & The Econometric Society)

2019: GCER Conference (Georgetown), Mortara Development Seminar (Georgetown)

Honors, Awards, Fellowships & Grants

Ronald H. Coase Best Dissertation Award, Honorable Mention, Society for Institutional & Organizational Economics (SIOE), 2024

ASHEcon Program Chair Award, Health and Development Program, The Annual Conference of the American Society of Health Economists, 2023

Private Enterprise Development in Low-Income Countries (PEDL) Exploratory Research Grant, with Reshmaan Hussam and Ameet Morjaria, ~ \$40,000, 2023

The Darla Moore School of Business Research Grant, \$5,000, 2023

Best Development/Applied Paper Award, Delhi Winter School, Delhi School of Economics & The Econometric Society, 2021

Harvard Kennedy School Women and Public Policy Program Research Fellowship, 2021-2022

6th Year Funding Competition Winner, Georgetown University, 2021

GradGov Research Project Award, Georgetown University, 2019

Graduate School Dissertation Travel Grant (for Rwanda), Georgetown University, 2019

Summer Research Grant, Georgetown University, 2019

Ph.D. Fellowship, Georgetown University, 2016

Sakip Sabanci Fellowship, Sabanci University, 2010-2013

Dean's List, Sabanci University, 2010-2013

Teaching

Instructor, University of South Carolina

Ph.D. Development Economics, Fall 2023, 2025

Undergraduate Gender Inequality across the Globe, Spring 2025, Fall 2025

Undergraduate Introductory Econometrics, Fall 2022, 2023, 2025, Spring 2025

Undergraduate International Development Economics, Fall 2022, 2023

Teaching Assistant

Ph.D. Econometrics II, Georgetown University, Spring 2018, 2019, 2020

Masters Econometrics, Georgetown University, Fall 2018, 2019

Undergraduate Introduction to Econometrics, Georgetown University, Fall 2017, Spring 2021

Undergraduate Microeconometrics, Georgetown University, Fall 2021

Undergraduate Economic Analysis of Law, Georgetown University, Fall 2020

Undergraduate Macroeconomics, Sabanci University, Spring 2012

Professional Activities

Referee: American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, American Economic Review, Economic Development and Cultural Change, Feminist Economics, Health Economics, Journal of Development Economics, Journal of European Economic Association, Journal of Health Economics, Journal of Political Economy, Quarterly Journal of Economics, Review of Economics and Statistics, The Economic Journal, World Development

Service: UofSC Hiring Committee (2023-2024), UofSC Ph.D. Admissions Committee (2023-2024)

Pre-PhD Employment

Research Associate, Department of Economics, Duke University, 2015-2016

Languages

English (fluent), German (intermediate), French (beginner), Turkish (native)

Personal

Date of Birth: 05/20/1991

Place of Birth: Istanbul, Turkey

Citizenship: Turkish